Your Family's Part, in Order

From a list of what Dad owns to a page of questions for a professional: ten actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: you can hand a professional one dated page that shows what Dad owns, how each thing is owned, and the questions your family would want answered before anything changes.

Nothing here has to be settled this month. Take it a little at a time. Put a name next to each action, add a date if that helps, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Sit down with Dad and list what he owns: the home and any other real estate, cash and savings, investments, retirement accounts, insurance and annuities, personal property, any business interest. Put the date at the top.			
2. Find the deed to the home and note whose name is on it, as the deed reads.			
3. For each account, note whose name is on it and whether it's held jointly with anyone.			
4. For each retirement account, insurance policy and annuity, note the named beneficiary from the form or a statement.			
5. If Dad has a trust, note where its papers are and which things on the list are held in its name.			
6. If Dad is married, note which things are in his name, which are in his spouse's, and which are in both.			
7. Write down any change the family has talked about, such as a gift, a name added to an account or a different deed. Next to each, write what you'd want to ask a professional first. This action is only the writing down; nothing changes at this step.			
8. Sort your questions into legal ones for an elder law attorney, including how estate recovery works in Dad's state, and financial ones for a licensed financial professional.			
9. Agree as a family on the events that would send you back to the list, such as a change in Dad's health, a move, a sale of property or a death in the family.			
10. Keep the list current. When an account opens or closes, or a beneficiary form changes, update the line and its date.			

You're done when

What Dad owns, whose name is on each thing, what you couldn't confirm and your questions are all on one dated page, each question with the kind of professional it goes to written beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list: the review of the list, the answers about what may be protectable in Dad's state, and any decision about a deed, an account, a trust or a product. Those belong with your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney and the appropriate licensed professionals.

If it goes slowly

- Don't fill a blank by guessing. “Not sure yet” is a finished line.
- If Dad would prefer not to go through everything at once, start with the one thing he's happy to talk about and come back to the rest another day.
- If someone in the family would like to make a change now, add it to action 7 as a question and take it to an elder law attorney first.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't determine Medicaid eligibility, confirm that any asset is protected, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for. Rules vary by state and change. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've worked through your family's part, a little at a time. The planning interview goes through your family's situation with you in order, including the parts a list leaves out, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›